MEN OF THE SWORD AND THE PEN

The rather niggardly amount that Akbar was able to obtain from Maham Anaga in an emergency was only a minor incident but it was symptomatic of a much larger and potentially disastrous problem in this fledgling Mughal Empire—a severely depleted treasury. Land revenue had long been a source of wealth and income for the monarchs of Hindustan, the wealth of the rulers depending on their ability to profit from the agrarian productivity of India, while taxes on trade, manufacture, and other activity were a great deal less important to the overall revenue, most estimates putting them at less than 10 per cent of the total earnings. Akbar's predecessors had usually contented themselves with seizing the treasures of defeated opponents, as Babur had done with Ibrahim Lodi after the Battle of Panipat. Commanders of the victorious party were then appointed an appanage, or iqta, from which to extract revenue. These iqtas were often managed in a predatory manner by the commanders, and also had a tendency to become hereditary. Akbar now took stock of the financial debacle in the empire, which had arisen due to outdated land revenue information from Sher Shah Sur's reign being used to extract taxes. The situation had been further exacerbated by Bairam Khan's excessive largesse, as he had handed out huge cash incentives to bind men to his cause.

In the 1560s unhappy, therefore, with the inaccuracy of these estimates for tax based on land size, crop yield, and market price, which had continued from the time of Sher Shah Sur, Akbar directed his men to begin collecting data on the actual market prices and revenue rates of various crops in the provinces of Agra, Allahabad, Awadh, Delhi, Lahore, Multan, and Malwa. The officials were directed to be as fair and accountable as possible, as described by Abu'l Fazl:

> The collector was directed to be the friend of the agriculturist; to give remissions in order to stimulate cultivation…to grant every facility to the raiyat [farmer] and never to charge him on more than the actual area under tillage; to receive the assessment direct from the cultivator and so avoid intermediaries; to recover arrears without